

WA.5 Forms & Documents Index

Every document a Washington owner-builder meets — what each one is, when it is needed, and which of the four agencies it comes from.

Before you use this document

This is a process reference, not legal advice. Washington's building code is written by the State and enforced locally by 39 counties and hundreds of cities and towns, each with its own forms and fees — and your electrical permit may come from a different agency altogether. Confirm every item with the department that will issue your permit before you rely on it. Form names and numbers are local; the obligations behind them are not.

Documents a Washington owner-builder will encounter

Document	What it is and when you need it	Where it comes from
Building permit application	The main application. For any project over \$5,000 the statute fixes minimum contents, including the prime contractor's registration number — the line owner-builders have nothing to write on. Ask how your office wants it handled. When: after water, sewage and zoning are lined up. Completeness is what vests you.	City or county building department
Owner-builder acknowledgment	There is no statewide form . Most jurisdictions use their own acknowledgment that you are building on your own property and are exempt from contractor registration. When: at application — ask for it by name before you file.	City or county — local form
Notice about unregistered contractors	Not something you file — something you are owed . At issuance the jurisdiction must print the contractor registration number on the permit and give you written notice of the registration laws and " <i>the potential risk and monetary liability to the homeowner for using an unregistered contractor.</i> " If nobody hands it to you, ask.	City or county, at issuance
Evidence of adequate water supply	A purveyor's letter stating the ability to serve, a water right permit, or another sufficient form. A water right application is expressly not sufficient proof. When: with the building permit application — it is a statutory precondition, not a formality.	Water purveyor, or Ecology

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WRIA fee receipt and recorded restriction	In 15 water resource inventory areas a new permit-exempt domestic connection carries a \$500 fee paid to the permitting authority, a reduced withdrawal cap (950 or 3,000 gallons per day depending on the basin), and restrictions recorded against your title. When: at building permit. Confirm the current figure for your basin.	City or county, under RCW 90.94
Water well report (well log)	Filed by the driller for a new well and constructed under chapter 18.104 RCW. Outside the regulated basins, a well report consistent with that chapter is itself a recognized way to demonstrate physical and legal water availability. Keep your copy.	Licensed well driller; Ecology
On-site sewage permit application	Carries the soil and site evaluation, a dimensioned site plan showing the initial and reserve areas, and a design bearing the designer's name, signature and stamp. The health officer must respond within 30 days; the permit may not run more than five years. When: start the soil evaluation first, before anything else.	Local health jurisdiction
Owner-installer permission	The local health officer may allow the resident owner of a single-family residence to install their own system — not within 200 feet of marine water, not within 100 feet of surface water, and not where Table X standards apply. Discretionary. Get it in writing.	Local health jurisdiction
Electrical work permit	A separate permit from a separate agency, bought before the work starts. Nothing may be concealed until the inspector approves it, and the utility may not connect until L&I has approved. When: before temporary power, and again for the house.	L&I — or an incorporated city running its own program
Plumbing and mechanical permits	Issued locally under the Uniform Plumbing Code and the mechanical code. Doing the work yourself under a homeowner exemption does not waive them.	City or county building department
Energy credit documentation	<i>"The drawings included with the building permit application shall identify which options have been selected and the point value of each option."</i> Not an attachment — it belongs on the drawings. When: at application.	You, on your plan set
Three signed test reports	Blower door (4.0 ACH50), duct leakage, and ventilation airflow verification. Each produces a written report signed by the testing party and provided to the code official. When: late, but book the tester early — in rural counties they set your schedule.	Your testing agency, to the code official

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Critical areas, shoreline, or SEPA documents	Where a wetland, stream, steep slope, geologic hazard, floodplain or shoreline designation touches your parcel, or where the project triggers environmental review. These run on their own timeline and are the most common cause of a long Washington permit. When: ask before you buy the land, if you still can.	City or county planning
Road approach permit	From WSDOT if your driveway meets a state highway; otherwise from the county or city road authority. Establish which road you are actually connecting to before you assume.	WSDOT, county, or city
Certificate of occupancy	Issued by the building department at the end, under the administrative provisions of the adopted International Residential Code. Ask early what it wants in hand — commonly every trade final including the electrical one, the energy test reports, and septic approval.	City or county building department

One more document you will meet every month: the invoice

Washington taxes construction **labor**, and people arriving from states that do not are caught by it. Building a house for your own occupancy makes you the **consumer**. Every trade you hire directly is therefore a "prime contractor" performing for a consumer, and prime contractors *"are required to collect from consumers the retail sales tax measured by the full contract price"* — labor included, and including permit and license fees the contractor paid and passes on.

The state rate alone is **6.5 percent** and local rates sit on top of it, so on a house this is a real line in the budget rather than a rounding error. Look up the combined rate for your exact site address at **dor.wa.gov**, and budget it against every subcontractor invoice — not just against materials. (WAC 458-20-170(4)(a); RCW 82.08.020(1))

Sources (verified August 2026 at app.leg.wa.gov): application contents over \$5,000, and their appearance on the permit and the posted inspection record card — RCW 19.27.095(2), (3). Evidence of an adequate water supply, and a water right application not being sufficient proof — RCW 19.27.097(1). The \$500 fee, the reduced caps and recording against title — RCW 90.94.020(5)(f), RCW 90.94.030(3); both apply "until rules have been adopted that specify otherwise," so confirm your basin. Well construction and the well report — chapter 18.104 RCW. Registration number printed on the permit and the written notice about unregistered contractors — RCW 18.27.110(2). Electrical permit, concealment, and utility connection — RCW 19.28.101(4), (5). On-site sewage application contents, the 30-day response and the five-year limit — WAC 246-272A-0200(2), (4)(a), (4)(f); owner installation — WAC 246-272A-0250(2). Energy credits on the drawings — WAC 51-11R-40620. The three test reports — WAC 51-11R-40240, 51-11R-40320, 51-11R-40350. Retail sales tax on the full contract price — WAC 458-20-170(4)(a) with the 6.5 percent state rate at RCW 82.08.020(1); local rates are additional and change, so use the Department of Revenue's own lookup.